

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

56-95-102

Accepted (6-1)

PURPLE FINCH

Carpodacus purpureus

Location: Tree lot at the corner of JJ and 16 Rd; 1 mile E. of Ft. Lyons; Bent County, Colorado

Date: November 19, 1995

This bird was originally found by Van Truan and Brandon Percival the week before. I saw it with Brandon Percival for about 10 minutes starting at about 12:15 p.m. It was still in the tree lot where they had found it. It was loosely associated with a flock of about 6 House Finches. I watched it in excellent light conditions with my B & L Elite 10 x 40 binoculars. It perched about 20 feet up in a birch, about 15 feet up in a leafless elm, and later about six feet up on a dried sunflower head. It was 25-40 feet away. The bird was silent.

Description:

This was a female-plumaged bird. It was superficially like a female House Finch -- about the same size and pattern. In shape it differed from the House Finch by being noticeably plumper, proportionately bigger-headed, much shorter-tailed, and the tail had a slight notch. The bird was brown above and lighter below. The back was dark brown and streaked. The wings were brown with two ill-defined buffy wingbars. The crown was brown and streaked. The face had a distinct whitish superciliary, a brown eye patch, a white border to the bottom edge of the patch and a brown moustache line bordering the lower edge of this whitish line. The undersides were white and heavily streaked with rows of distinct brown spots. The under-belly and undertail coverts were pure, unstreaked white. I was able to see and remark on the undertail pattern due to one overhead view I got of the bird. The bill was dark gray and rather large when compared to the House Finch bill. The bill had a curved culmen. [See sketch from field notes]

Similar Species:

See above. House Finch is a slimmer, longer-tailed bird. In direct comparisons to this Purple Finch, female House Finches were dingier, less distinctly streaked below, had dark streaks on the undertail coverts, and completely lacked the distinct two-toned face pattern. Cassin's Finch has a longer, straighter bill, has a less distinct face pattern, has a buffier underparts, and has streaks on the undertail coverts.

Experience with Species:

I have seen many Purple, Cassin's and House finches.

This report is prepared from notes made following observation.

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Crown streaked. Underside
white w/ rather marked
rows or streaks on breast.
Under belly, & under tail
coverts pure white. Bill
dark gray; rather large
compared to HF bill.
Slightly curved culmen.

